ENG-0005 Incident Postmortem: INC-089

Impact

The incident involving the auth-worker system (SYS-004) on January 21, 2025, resulted in a Sev1 severity classification, indicating a critical disruption to the system's functionality. The auth-worker system, which is integral to our authentication processes, is designated as high criticality within our infrastructure. The disruption affected core authentication services, potentially impacting user access and system security protocols. The resolution of this incident took approximately 4.5 hours, during which operational stability was compromised, and user experience was adversely affected.

Timeline

- **January 21, 2025**: The incident was reported by Jamie Arnold, Head of Data & Analytics, via internal channels. The initial detection indicated a significant failure within the auth-worker system.
- **Immediately following detection**: Crystal Robinson, Project Manager and on-call engineer for auth-worker, was mobilized to address the issue.
- **Incident Response**: The on-call engineer, Crystal Robinson, diagnosed the problem as stemming from a configuration change. The root cause was identified as a recent configuration modification within the auth-worker system.
- **Resolution**: The configuration change was reverted, restoring system functionality. The total resolution time was 4.5 hours.
- **Post-incident**: A review was conducted to understand the cause and prevent recurrence.

Root Cause

The root cause of INC-089 was identified as a configuration change within the auth-worker system. This change was implemented without sufficient validation, leading to a failure in the authentication service. The change was likely introduced as part of ongoing updates under Project Juniper, which is managed by the owner project team. The incident underscores the importance of rigorous change management procedures, especially for systems of high criticality.

Action Items

Item	Description	Responsible	Due Date	Notes
1	Implement stricter change approval process for configuration modifications in auth-worker	Project Juniper Lead (E-090)	2025-02-15	Ensure all changes undergo peer review and testing prior to deployment
2	Enhance monitoring and alerting for auth-worker system to detect configuration anomalies	Infrastructure Team	2025-02-20	Improve early detection and response capabilities
3			2025-02-25	

Item	Description	Responsible	Due Date	Notes
	Conduct a training session on change management best practices for the auth-worker team	HR & Training Department		Focus on high-criticality systems and proper validation procedures
4	Review and update incident response procedures specific to configuration-related failures	Incident Response Team	2025-02-28	Streamline response times and escalation protocols
5	Document lessons learned from INC-089 and share with all relevant teams	Project Juniper Lead (E-090)	2025-03-05	Foster a culture of continuous improvement

Additional Notes

This incident was reported by Jamie Arnold and managed by Crystal Robinson, who is the on-call engineer for auth-worker. The auth-worker system, part of Project Juniper, is critical to our operations, and this event highlights the necessity for robust change management and monitoring practices. Moving forward, these measures aim to prevent similar incidents and ensure system resilience.